History Lesson

by Don Trickseven

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Let me tell you a joke. My friend Jake killed himself last week. A couple weeks ago now, about a month before the end of our junior year in high school. So here's the punchline: Jake texted his suicide note. It was, technically, a suicide text. But he'd just gotten a new iPhone, and they made him change his number. Why he got a new phone the day before he killed himself, I don't know. It's not like the phone survived the fall. So why'd he bother getting it? I know his parents didn't buy it for him, Mr. Stonebridge is the friendly miser type, and Mrs. Stonebridge wouldn't know an iPhone from a WiiMote if her life depended on it.

So Jake got a new phone just in time to text all his friends his suicide note. Which meant he had to reenter all the numbers of his contacts. And he entered mine wrong. So after it happened, everyone knew. And they were scared to call me because they thought I'd know, I was Jake's friend, obviously I got the text, and if I needed to talk or whatever, I'd call them. But I didn't get the text because Jake put it in his phone wrong, so it wasn't until 24 hours later some idiot girl I barely knew posted on my facebook wall a simple "sorry" and I posted back "sorry for what" and this girl sent me such an angry message that I finally called our other friend, Mark. He forwarded me the text.

Here let me read it to you. You won't believe what Jake wrote. (*he opens his phone.*) Oh, no. Wait, sorry. I deleted it. I forgot that.

What did it say? You know, I only read it once. I thought I kept it. Maybe I hit the wrong button, or something. I was upset. Maybe I thought I wouldn't want to read it again. Well, I'll just have Mark forward it to me again... (*he stares at the phone.*) Later.

So, I'm not going to make you wait until the end, to figure out why Jake did it. I hate when they do that, in movies and such. Show you the dead body but then you have to wait the whole time to figure out why he's dead.

My friend killed himself because he was in love with his teacher. How do I know this? Well, get this, the Stonebridges asked me to help go through Jake's things. I guess his parents were a little afraid. They pretended like they were being nice, you know, Jake would want me to go through his stuff, but I knew they were afraid. I was glad to help, you know, you like to feel useful at times like this, when I am realizing no one is useful because there is absolutely nothing useful to do. I knew Jake's writing pretty well. It was typical insane guy stuff. In 8th grade he wrote a whole novel about a squadron of heavily armed hamsters fighting an unbelievably violent war against a dark legion of ghost ferrets. But I mean, that's not like suspicious or anything. if I had a friend who *didn't* think it was funny to see an evil ferret's head get blown off, then I would have been suspicious.

I was surprised when I found Jake's journal. I would have never pegged him for the journal-keeping type. It was between two stacks of school notebooks in a bin under his bed, disguised, quite cleverly, as yet another school notebook filled with notes about the War of 1812, otherwise known as the war fought just so we could learn about it in school, fail a pop quiz about it, then never think about it again for the rest of our lives. I only opened it because I literally could not remember a single thing about the War of 1812, and I wanted to read about it in Jake's ridiculous notes, which usually added things like "he was the only President who attributed his success to eating a smoothie made of dog turds in the morning," again, pretty brilliant.

So anyway, two pages into the notes, it's suddenly his journal. He seemed like a typically unhappy teenager. Life will never be complete, has no meaning, etcetera. I know what you're thinking. That he should have gotten help, that he spiraled into despair. But as I read through it, the opposite was true. The entries got happier and happier as they went along, because more and more they were about Mrs. Carmichael, the aforementioned history teacher with whom, it is now clear to me, Jake was becoming quite intimate, the translation of that sarcastic teenage phrase being they were humping.

Anyway, let me read the key entries.

Today Mrs. Carmichael caught me looking at her, again. Except when I looked back to see if she'd really caught me, she was staring back, kind of smiling. I smiled back, then I felt like a dumbass so I looked back down and tried to do my quiz. I failed the quiz. Mrs. Carmichael handed it back to me at the end of class with an A on it. I covered it up. I was embarrassed, I didn't want anyone to see she had given me credit on the wrong answers.

It proceeds from there. Two weeks later.

I walked Mrs. Carmichael to her car. We were talking about the Quiz Team. She said we should all have practice at her house. The whole team should come over. I could tell she wanted just me to come. I told her I wasn't sure if I could come next weekend. Then she got really mad, said I wasn't dedicated to the team or whatever. I thought girls got crazy but Mrs. Carmichael was at another level. No wonder Dad sometimes spends nights away from us, if Mom is like that. But I told Mrs. Carmichael I'd definitely come. She smiled and I smiled back without looking away.

Are you hoping that Jake wrote about that night at Mrs. Carmichael's? Well he most certainly did, and I think he did it while he was still drunk!

Oh man, oh man that was fun. Me and Tammy (That's Mrs. Carmichael) *we talked through everything. She's such a cool teacher. She really got me. She got my life, she's been through it all. And she's so cool! Like a cucumber. A frozen cucumber. With smooth skin. Like a cucumber.*

Drunk Jake was apparently fascinated by this image. Obviously things were heating up. He goes on, from a few days later.

Damn I did not think it would be like that. In her car, parked by the empty mall. Her hair was like midnight gold and I had it in my hand. Damn damn damn. Love, when it comes, is extraordinary. I did not think I would be so corny but I can't help myself. I want it so much, everything. She told me I was her dream come true. I told her the same thing.

And then of course, at the very end, things went bad. Jake didn't write about it, per se; but those of us with three brain cells can put two and two together from this entry.

I guess dreams never quite come true. I guess happiness is an illusion, and we're all here to suffer. Whatever. I guess when you have something you have to hold onto it really tight. Because you're going to lose it. It's going to die. That's how the world works. It gives you things so it can take them away. Or even worse it gives you them so you can fail at them.

She must have dumped him, or chickened out was the right word. No surprise here, that Jake was the strong one, and this harpie was a coward. She was not there for Jake. She was only doing it for herself, and she didn't realize. And then Jake saw himself like the War of 1812, something that happens, and everyone forgets about. He saw himself as useless, when all he really was, was hurt. And listen to the last thing Jake wrote.

I think I can still make it work. I think I can still show her that our love is strong enough. If I am strong enough to do it, our love is proven RIGHT.

I didn't tell anyone what I saw in Jake's journal. The day after I read the journal, I looked up where Mrs. Carmichael lives. And I drove there, kind of in a trance.

So there I was at Mrs. Carmichael's house. What was I gonna say? Obviously, there's the conventional play where I yell at her for Jake. Tell her she reached her hands up inside him and twisted until everything broke, until what we loved about Jake oozed out into the ground in little Jake-smelling puddles. But I

couldn't handle either reaction that she would have.

I drove away. I didn't tell anyone. Not even you, really. The names are changed and there's an actor up here, saying these words right now. No one will know about Jake and her. It's not a big deal. What stopped me from ever telling anyone, like Jake's parents or the authorities or whomever you deem appropriate to know about such a relationship, was that I could not stand thinking that suddenly it would not be about Jake anymore. That suddenly, Jake's life, and Jake's death, would be about him and Mrs. Carmichael. No one would talk about Jake without talking about her, no one could remember Jake without thinking about what happened. And I thought that would be unfair. I wanted Jake to be Jake, forever.

And of course she never said anything. Like I said, a coward.

Is that all the time we have? (*He looks at his phone)* Oh wait, I have the note. Here in my deleted folder, I forgot it had one of those. So do you want to hear it? Yes, you do. You sat here and listened to me hoping I'd get to something like that. So here goes.

From Jake Stonebridge, 10:43pm.

I love u all. Its the right thing 2 do. Miss u already. Wasnt meant for this world I have 2 much luv and nowhere for it to go. Will send it 2 u from beyond always.

Jake, buddy. I feel your love right now. But you were wrong, man. We always had a place for your love.